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First Export Kit
India 2026-27

From zero to your first shipping bill

registrations · documents · pricing · payment · claims

RULES CHECKED 3 NOVEMBER 2026

DGFT · CBIC · RBI · GSTN

A DIGITALAIKART ORIGINAL

Edition 2026-27 · Digital Edition

Before you start

This kit is written for one person: someone in India with a product, a bank account and no export experience. It assumes you have never filed a shipping bill, do not know what an AD Code is, and have no consultant on retainer.

Every procedural fact here was checked against the issuing authority — DGFT notifications, CBIC circulars and notifications, RBI's FEMA regulations and the GST portal's own user guides — on **3 November 2026**. Where a rule has an expiry date, the date is printed next to it. Where a cost is a market rate rather than a government fee, it says so.

The order to read it in

If you are starting from zero, read Chapters 1 to 4 in order and stop. That is the whole of your registration work, and it takes about a week. Come back to Chapter 6 when you have a buyer, Chapter 7 when you have a shipment, and Chapter 9 when the money is due.

If you already have an IEC and a buyer waiting, go straight to Chapter 5 to pick your channel, then Chapter 7 for the document set, then Chapter 8 to price it. Chapters 10 and 11 are where most first-timers quietly lose money — read them before you file, not after.

What this kit will not do

It will not classify your product for you, file anything on a portal for you, or replace a customs broker. Classification and filing carry legal responsibility that sits with you. What it will do is tell you exactly which portal, which field, which document and which deadline, so that the professional you hire is doing the work you paid for instead of discovering your business for you.

> **A word on dates**
> Export rules in India move fast. RoDTEP was extended twice in 2026 and its rates were cut and then restored within a month. Treat this kit as a map of the system, and the notification number beside each rule as the thing you verify on dgft.gov.in before you act on a number that matters.

This is a guide, not legal, tax or customs advice. For a specific shipment, confirm the position with your customs broker, your chartered accountant or the relevant authority.

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CHAPTER ONE

The rules changed in 2026

Eight changes between November 2025 and October 2026 rewrote the first-year maths for a new exporter. If you are working from a guide written before then, parts of it are already wrong.

The compliance stack itself — IEC, AD Code, LUT, HS code — has barely moved in a decade. What moved is the cost of getting in, the length of your payment clock, and the channels you are allowed to use. Those three things decide whether your first year of exporting makes money or just makes paperwork.

The eight changes that matter

Change	What it means for you	Source
Export proceeds must be realised in **15 months**, not 9	You have five extra months before a late payment becomes a FEMA contravention. Track it from the shipping bill date, not the invoice date.	FEMA 23(R)/(7)/2025-RB, 13 Nov 2025
Advance payment against export: shipment window **3 years**, not 1	If a buyer pays upfront, you can take longer to ship without approaching RBI.	Same notification
Courier export value cap of **₹10 lakh removed** (1 Apr 2026)	A courier consignment can now carry any commercial value. No more splitting an order to stay under the cap.	CBIC Notif. 33/2026-Cus (N.T.) and 34/2026-Cus (N.T.), Circular 17/2026-Customs
RoDTEP runs only to 31 December 2026	The remission scheme has a hard date. Any shipment you want the benefit on must have its Let Export Order inside the window.	DGFT Notification 41/2026-27, 30 Sep 2026
RCMC not required for consignments up to **₹3 lakh FOB**	A first courier or small cargo shipment no longer needs council membership bought in advance.	DGFT Notification 36/2026-27, 15 Sep 2026
Inventory-based cross-border e-commerce framework live (5 Aug 2026)	A new legal route: sell to a registered Exporter-on-Record who handles compliance, and get paid within 7 days of acceptance.	DGFT Notification 27/2026-27 and Public Notice 25/2026-27
Small-value EDPMS closure up to **₹10 lakh** on your declaration	Shipping bills below the threshold can be closed by your AD bank on quarterly declarations, instead of a bank-by-bank reconciliation.	RBI relaxation for small-value exporters
Export Promotion Mission: **₹25,060 crore** for 2025–31	Two sub-schemes — Niryat Protsahan for trade finance and Niryat Disha for market access — plus export credit for e-commerce and part-reimbursement of mandatory international certifications.	Department of Commerce, Export Promotion Mission

Sources are the notification or regulation that created the change. Verify the current position on dgft.gov.in before you rely on a figure for a live shipment.

The one-line version

The cheapest legitimate route to a first shipment in 2026-27 is a courier consignment below ₹3 lakh FOB: no RCMC to buy, no port queue, RoDTEP and duty drawback still claimable, and a fifteen-month payment clock. Start there, learn the document set, then move to sea cargo when the order is big enough to justify it.

What did not change

- **IEC is still mandatory** for any commercial export, still costs ₹500 on dgft.gov.in, and still has to be updated every year between 1 April and 30 June or it deactivates.
- **AD Code still has to be live on ICEGATE** at the port you are loading from before a shipping bill can be filed. There is no workaround for this.
- **The LUT is still filed every financial year** in Form GST RFD-11, before your first export invoice of that year.
- **The 8-digit HS code still decides everything**: export policy, RoDTEP rate, drawback rate, the duty your buyer pays, and whether a Certificate of Origin can claim preference.
- **Document mismatches are still the number one cause of delay.** Not missing documents — mismatched ones.

How to read a DGFT notification in sixty seconds

You will spend the next few years reading these, so here is the structure. Every notification follows the same shape, and the part that matters is almost never the part that is longest.

- **The number is a year and a sequence.** Notification 41/2026-27 is the forty-first notification of the 2026-27 financial year. Quoting it exactly is how you win an argument with a customs officer or a consultant.
- **Read the last paragraph first.** Every DGFT notification ends with 'Effect of this notification', which states the change in one sentence. If that sentence does not affect you, stop reading.
- **Rates are not in the notification.** They sit in the appendices it points to — Appendix 4R for RoDTEP, Appendix 4RE for Advance Authorisation, EOU and SEZ shipments. The notification extends the scheme; the appendix sets the money.
- **Check the operative date, not just the issue date.** A notification issued on 30 September 2026 can apply from 1 October, or retrospectively from an earlier date. Both dates are printed; they are not the same thing.

Three deadlines that will bite in the next twelve months

1. **31 December 2026** — RoDTEP's notified end date. Plan shipments you want covered to reach Let Export Order before this.
2. **1 April 2027** — a fresh LUT for FY 2027-28 must be on file before your first export invoice of that year.
3. **30 June 2027** — the IEC annual update window (1 April to 30 June) closes. Miss it and the IEC deactivates automatically; reactivation is free but your shipments stop until it is done.

CHAPTER TWO

What the first shipment really costs

Not the marketing version. The actual line items, which are government fees, which are market rates you can negotiate, and the number you should budget before you spend a rupee.

One-time setup costs

Item	Cost	Nature
IEC (Importer Exporter Code)	₹500	Government fee, one-time, paid on the DGFT portal
GST registration	Nil	Government fee is nil; a consultant may charge for filing
LUT in Form GST RFD-11	Nil	Self-filed on the GST portal, renewed each financial year
AD Code registration on ICEGATE	Nil	Your bank issues the letter; you register it port-wise
ICEGATE registration	Nil	Needed for shipping bills and document uploads
Udyam (MSME) registration	Nil	Not legally compulsory; unlocks MSME benefits and priority lending
Class 3 digital signature, if you need one	₹1,200 – ₹2,000	Market rate. Aadhaar e-sign is free where the portal accepts it
RCMC from an Export Promotion Council	₹2,000 – ₹10,000	Market rate, council-dependent. Not needed under ₹3 lakh FOB

Per-shipment costs

Item	Typical range	Notes
Customs broker (CHA) fee	₹2,000 – ₹6,000 per shipping bill	Market rate, negotiable, higher at congested ports
Inland freight to port or airport	Quote-based	Depends on weight, distance and whether it is LCL
Terminal handling and port charges	Quote-based	Usually passed through by the CHA at cost
Ocean or air freight	Quote-based	On FOB terms the buyer pays this, not you
Courier export (door-to-door)	Quote-based per kg	Cheapest route for parcels under about 30 kg
Product testing or certification	₹5,000 – ₹2,00,000+	Only where the destination market demands it. This is the line that surprises people
Certificate of Origin	Nil to a few hundred rupees	Filed on the DGFT electronic platform

There is no such thing as an export licence to buy

The IEC costs ₹500 and takes a day or two on dgft.gov.in. If anyone quotes you ₹40,000 or ₹50,000 for an 'export registration package', you are being sold a week of form-filling at consultant rates. Pay a professional for classification, documentation and filing — not for the registration itself.

The honest minimum to get to a first shipment

A proprietorship with a current account can be export-ready for roughly **₹8,000 to ₹15,000** in setup and first-shipment costs, excluding the goods themselves and freight. That figure covers the IEC fee, a digital signature if you need one, one courier or CHA charge, and a small document and stationery buffer. Everything else in the table above is either nil or optional at the start.

How long it actually takes

Stage	Realistic time	What usually slows it down
Entity, PAN and current account	1 – 7 days	Banks asking for business proof you do not have yet
IEC	1 – 3 working days	Name mismatch between PAN, bank and address proof
GST registration	3 – 7 working days	Officer query on address proof; simplified auto-approval is faster
AD Code on ICEGATE	Same day to 3 days	Bank letter formatting; PFMS validation failing on a name mismatch
RCMC, if you need one	1 – 3 weeks	No verified government service level; councils vary widely
First shipment, after all of the above	1 – 3 weeks	Buyer confirmation, production, and the forwarder's cut-off

So: about two weeks of registration and one to three weeks of shipment, assuming nothing goes wrong and your product is already made. If you have not started, the realistic answer is **four to six weeks from today to a Let Export Order**.

CHAPTER THREE

Is your product exportable

Four checks, in this order, before you spend anything. The fourth one is the one nobody does and the one that costs the most.

You can waste a month and a lot of money registering to export something that customs will not let out, or that the destination will not let in. Run these four checks first. All of them are free.

Check 1 — The 8-digit code and its export policy

Every product has an 8-digit ITC(HS) code. Schedule 2 of ITC(HS) 2022, the Export Policy, tells you whether that code is **Free**, **Restricted**, **Prohibited** or reserved for **State Trading Enterprises**. Free means you can ship it. Restricted means you need a licence or authorisation from DGFT first. Prohibited means you cannot ship it at all.

You look this up on dgft.gov.in under ITC(HS) Schedule 2. Read the policy condition column, not just the policy word — a product can be 'Free' with a condition attached, such as a minimum export price or a quality certificate.

Check 2 — SCOMET

Appendix 3 to Schedule 2 of ITC(HS) is the SCOMET list: dual-use and strategic items with military or weapons applications. Most first-time exporters of textiles, food, handicrafts or furniture never touch it. But it catches people in chemicals, electronics, drones, certain machine tools, sensors and laboratory equipment. If your product sits anywhere near those categories, read the SCOMET list before you take an order.

Check 3 — The product regulator

Product line	Regulator or council	What they gate
Apparel and textiles	AEPC	Council membership, textile schemes, buyer meets
Spices	Spices Board India	Mandatory registration for spice exports, quality certification
Marine products	MPEDA	Registration and pre-shipment inspection
Fresh produce, rice, pulses, processed food	APEDA	Registration-cum-membership, phytosanitary coordination
Pharmaceuticals and bulk drugs	Pharmexcil, CDSCO	Council membership, drug export permissions, CoPP
Gems and jewellery	GJEPC	Kimberley Process certification for rough diamonds
Handicrafts and carpets	EPCH	Council membership, craft-specific schemes
Engineering goods	EEPC India	Council membership, engineering trade facilitation
Leather and footwear	CLE	Council membership, finished leather restrictions
Multi-product or unsure	FIEO	The general-purpose council for mixed product lines

Council membership is not needed for a consignment up to ₹3 lakh FOB (DGFT Notification 36/2026-27). It is needed when you want an Advance Authorisation, EPCG, or council-run market access support.

Check 4 — The destination's rules, not India's

This is where first shipments die. India lets your product out; the destination refuses it at the border, and the buyer cancels. Check the destination's requirement before you quote, not after.

Market	What to check
European Union	CE marking where the product is in scope; GPSR product safety and an EU responsible person; packaging EPR registration in Germany under VerpackG; food contact material rules
United Kingdom	UKCA marking and a UK responsible person; separate UK rules now that UK is outside the EU regime
United States	FDA registration and prior notice for food; FTC labelling; state-level chemical rules
Gulf (UAE, Saudi, Qatar)	ESMA or SFDA product registration; SABER for Saudi; halal certification for food; Arabic labelling
Africa and South Asia	Usually lighter, but check pre-shipment inspection requirements and whether a Certificate of Origin is demanded before payment release

The three questions

Can I legally ship this out of India? Will the destination legally let it in? Can I land it at a price a buyer will pay, after compliance costs? If any answer is no, change the product or change the market — do not register first and find out later.

CHAPTER FOUR

The registration stack, in order

Seven steps, one week of work. Each one has a portal, a field that people get wrong, and a consequence for skipping it.

#	What you are getting	Where	Cost	Time
1	Entity, PAN and a current account in the firm's name	Bank branch	Nil	1 – 7 days
2	IEC (Importer Exporter Code)	dgft.gov.in	₹500	1 – 3 days
3	GST registration	gst.gov.in	Nil	3 – 7 days
4	LUT in Form GST RFD-11 for the financial year	gst.gov.in	Nil	Same day
5	ICEGATE registration and AD Code at your port	icegate.gov.in	Nil	Same day to 3 days
6	Udyam (MSME) registration	udyamregistration.gov.in	Nil	Same day
7	RCMC — only if you need an FTP authorisation	DGFT e-RCMC module	Council fee	1 – 3 weeks

Step 2 — The IEC

Apply on dgft.gov.in under IEC Profile Management. You need the entity's PAN, a cancelled cheque or bank certificate, address proof, and the constitution document for a firm or company. Sign with a digital signature or Aadhaar e-sign and pay ₹500 on the Bharatkosh step. The IEC is issued against your PAN, so the number is your PAN — but a PAN in a drawer is not an IEC, and you still have to apply.

- **The annual update is not optional.** Between 1 April and 30 June every year you log in and confirm your details. It is free and takes minutes. Miss 30 June and the IEC deactivates; reactivation is automatic once you file, but any shipment in the meantime stops.
- **Never lend your IEC.** Shipments moving on someone else's IEC are the classic customs fraud pattern. The FTDR Act allows suspension, penalties from ₹10,000 up to five times the goods value, and entry in the Denied Entity List, which blocks every future authorisation you apply for.
- **Keep the address current.** A stale address on the IEC profile is one of the most common triggers for a Denied Entity List flag.

Step 3 and 4 — GST and the LUT

Exports are zero-rated supplies. You have two legal ways to handle that, and the choice is not cosmetic:

Route	What happens	Refund route	Best for
Export under LUT	No IGST charged on the invoice. Your input credit accumulates.	Refund of accumulated ITC in Form GST RFD-01 (Rule 89)	Regular exporters with input credit to recover
Export on payment of IGST	You charge and pay IGST, then recover it	Shipping bill itself is the refund application (Rule 96)	Occasional exporters, or where you cannot use ITC

File the LUT on gst.gov.in under **Services User Services Furnish Letter of Undertaking**, in Form GST RFD-11. The ARN is generated instantly. Select the correct financial year in the field 'LUT Applied for Financial Year' — that single field is what people get wrong, and a later LUT does not convert an IGST invoice you have already issued into an LUT supply.

Your invoice has to say it out loud

An export invoice under LUT must carry the declaration *"Supply meant for export without payment of IGST under LUT"*, the LUT ARN and its validity. A domestic GST invoice with a '0% IGST' line added is not an export invoice, and it is one of the standard reasons a refund gets rejected.

Step 5 — ICEGATE and the AD Code

The AD Code is a 14-digit identifier your bank issues that maps one branch account to one customs location. Register it on icegate.gov.in against the port or ICD you will actually load from, before your first shipping bill. Without a live AD Code the customs broker simply cannot file.

- CBIC Circular 24/2025-Customs (7 October 2025) auto-approves the same account and IFSC at additional customs locations, so you register once properly and the rest is faster.
- A different account or IFSC at a new port still goes through the officer queue.
- PFMS bank validation runs after ICEGATE approval. If it fails, your IGST refund and duty drawback will not credit — check that the account name matches the IEC legal name exactly before you file anything.

The name-match rule that saves you a week

Your legal name must be identical across the PAN, the GST certificate, the cancelled cheque, the DGFT profile, the ICEGATE AD Code registration and the shipper field on the bill of lading. '*Sharma Exports Pvt Ltd*' and '*Sharma Exports Private Limited*' are two different names to a customs system. Pick one form and use it everywhere, forever.

Your annual compliance calendar

1 April – 30 June: IEC annual update (free, mandatory). April: fresh LUT for the new financial year. Every month: GSTR-1 Table 6A with shipping bill numbers, and GSTR-3B. Every month: reconcile shipping bills against e-BRCs, not once a year. 31 December 2026: RoDTEP's notified end date.

CHAPTER FIVE

Choosing your export channel

Five legitimate ways to get goods out of India in 2026-27, and the two that suit a first shipment.

Channel	How it works	Best for	Watch out for
Sea or air cargo	Customs broker files a shipping bill on ICEGATE; goods move through a port or ICD	Volume orders, pallets, containers	Longest setup; AD Code needed at that exact port
Courier export	International courier files under courier regulations; door pickup	Parcels, samples and D2C orders	The ₹10 lakh cap went on 1 April 2026 — weight and per-kg cost are now the constraint
India Post (Dak Ghar Niryat Kendra)	Post office export desk handles documentation and dispatch	Very small parcels, artisans, first tests	Over a thousand Dak Ghar Niryat Kendras are notified; the International Tracked Packet Service covers 41 countries
Marketplace fulfilment	Amazon Global Selling and similar handle logistics and duty collection	Consumer products sold direct to shoppers	You still need your own IEC and GST
Exporter-on-Record model	You sell to a registered EOR who exports in its own name and handles compliance	Manufacturers and artisans who want out of the paperwork	Live since 5 August 2026. Payment within 7 days of acceptance; rebates passed on pro-rata to FOB, with the EOR's charge capped at 10% of them

The Exporter-on-Record route, properly understood

The inventory-based cross-border e-commerce framework (DGFT Notification 27/2026-27 and Public Notice 25/2026-27, 5 August 2026) created a structure that did not exist before. A registered **Exporter-on-Record** buys from Indian **Sellers-on-Record** against a confirmed overseas order, exports in its own name, and carries the compliance load. Three protections are written into the framework:

- Payment must reach you **no later than 7 days** from acceptance, and cannot be made conditional on the overseas buyer paying the EOR.
- Duty drawback, RoDTEP and RoSCTL must be passed on in proportion to the FOB value of your goods, after an administrative charge **capped at 10%** of the gross rebate.
- You get visibility — final sale price, order status, tracking, destination — and the EOR must file an annual compliance certificate from a chartered or cost accountant within 90 days of the year end.

Which channel for shipment one

If the order is under ₹3 lakh FOB and fits in cartons, use courier or a DNK: no port, no RCMC to buy, RoDTEP and drawback still claimable (courier exports have had both since 12 September 2024), and the document set learned on a shipment small enough to survive a mistake.

CHAPTER SIX

The HS code that survives customs

Eight digits decide your export policy, your RoDTEP rate, your drawback rate, your buyer's duty and whether your Certificate of Origin is worth anything. Get it wrong and the shipping bill locks it in.

What the number actually is

India classifies goods on the ITC(HS) schedule, an eight-digit extension of the global Harmonised System. The first six digits are international and identical everywhere. Digits seven and eight are India's own statistical split. On the ICEGATE shipping bill the field is called RITC or CTSH — same thing, eight digits.

Why the code is the whole game

- **Export policy:** the code tells you whether the item is Free, Restricted or Prohibited. A restricted item shipped as free is a seizure risk, not a paperwork problem.
- **RoDTEP rate:** the rate is looked up by code in Appendix 4R (or 4RE for Advance Authorisation, EOU and SEZ shipments). No code, no rate.
- **Duty drawback:** the All Industry Rate is published by code.
- **Destination duty:** your buyer's customs duty is calculated on the code you declare. A wrong code can make your price uncompetitive or trigger a post-clearance demand for your buyer.
- **Origin:** preferential treatment under a trade agreement is tested against the code's origin rule. Get it wrong and the preference fails.

> **The irreversible point is the Let Export Order**
> Until the LEO is issued, a shipping bill can be amended. After it, that shipping bill pays RoDTEP and drawback at the code you filed. Lock the code on a written classification note before the first commercial invoice, not after the container is at the gate.

How to classify, in practice

1. Start with what the product **is**, not what it is called. Composition, construction, function and end use drive the heading. A 'gift box' is classified as the article inside or as packing, depending on presentation.
2. Use the General Rules for the Interpretation (GRI) in order. GRI 1 — the heading text and section notes — settles most products. Only move to GRI 3 when two headings genuinely compete.
3. Read the section and chapter notes. They exclude more products than any keyword search will tell you.
4. Check the 8-digit split in the Indian Customs Tariff, then check Schedule 2 for the export policy of that exact line.
5. Write it down. One page, dated, signed, with the reasoning. That note is your defence if customs questions the classification two years later.

A worked example

Cotton knitted men's T-shirts. Chapter 61 covers knitted apparel. Heading 6109 is 'T-shirts, singlets and other vests, knitted or crocheted'. The subheading for cotton is 6109 10. The Indian 8-digit line is **61091000**. That is the number that goes on the invoice, the packing list, the shipping bill and the Certificate of Origin — spelled identically, with the same product description, every time.

Now the same product in a poly-cotton blend, or with a coated print that changes the fabric character, may not sit in that line at all. That is why 'keyword search on a website' is not classification, and why a customs broker's five-minute sanity check on your note is money well spent.

> **One schedule change to know about**
> The RoDTEP schedule in Appendix 4R was realigned to the amended Customs Tariff with effect from 1 May 2026 (DGFT Notification 15/2026-27). If you are working from a 2024 or 2025 rate sheet, some lines have moved. Check the current Appendix 4R on dgft.gov.in.

Classification note — the one page to keep

Product description as it will appear on the invoice	
Composition and material breakdown	
Function, construction and end use	
8-digit ITC(HS) code	
GRI rule or chapter note relied on	
Export policy result from Schedule 2 (Free / Restricted / Prohibited)	
Destination tariff line, if the buyer has quoted one	
Date, prepared by, signature	

CHAPTER SEVEN

The six documents and the match test

A first shipment needs four to six documents, not twelve. What actually stops shipments is not a missing document — it is the same fact written two different ways on two of them.

Document 1 — The commercial (export) invoice

You create this. It is simultaneously your bill to the buyer, the basis for customs valuation, your GST tax invoice, and the document your bank uses for FEMA compliance. A domestic invoice with a zero-tax line is not a substitute. These fields are the ones that matter:

- Your legal name, address, GSTIN and IEC
- Buyer's full legal name, address and country
- Invoice number and date, in a consistent series
- **8-digit ITC(HS) code for every product line** — 4 or 6 digits is a common shipping bill rejection reason
- Description, quantity, unit of measure, unit price, line total
- Invoice value in the foreign currency **and** the INR equivalent, with the exchange rate used (the RBI reference rate on the invoice date)
- Incoterm and named place, for example FOB Nhava Sheva
- LUT declaration with the ARN and validity, or the IGST-paid declaration
- Place of supply: outside India, with the country
- Your bank details and the AD Code
- Country of origin: India
- Marks and numbers matching the packing list

Document 2 — The packing list

Carton count, dimensions, net and gross weight per carton, marks and numbers, and item-wise quantity that reconciles exactly to the invoice lines. Where the invoice says '100% cotton T-shirt', the packing list must not say 'cotton garment'. Same words, every document.

Document 3 — The shipping bill

Your customs broker files it on ICEGATE. It is the export declaration and, once the Let Export Order is issued, the basis for RoDTEP, drawback and GST refund claims. Two things you must confirm before it is filed, not after:

- The **RoDTEP claim flag** and the drawback flag are ticked, if the product is eligible. A blank flag is not repaired later.
- The item-level RITC code, quantity, unit and value match your invoice exactly. Ask to see the shipping bill checklist before submission — five minutes of reading prevents weeks of queries.

Document 4 — Bill of lading or air waybill

Issued by the carrier or forwarder. The **shipper name must be identical to the IEC legal name**. One word different — 'Pvt. Ltd.' against 'Private Limited' — and customs raises a query. Confirm the shipper field with your forwarder before the BL is drafted, not after.

Document 5 — Certificate of Origin

Filed on the DGFT electronic platform at coo.dgft.gov.in. Not always required, but buyers in the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Egypt and parts of Africa routinely refuse to release payment without one. It is also the document that converts a trade agreement into an actual duty saving for your buyer — India's agreement with the UAE and the one with the UK both depend on a valid CoO being presented.

Document 6 — The compliance certificates

Only where the product or the destination demands them: phytosanitary certificate, fumigation, health certificate, inspection certificate, halal, CE declaration of conformity, test reports. These are the documents with the longest lead times, so they set your shipment date. Check them first, not last.

The six-way match test

Before gate-in, put the invoice, the packing list, the shipping bill draft, the marks and weight list, the draft BL description and the certificate set side by side. Then check these seven things across all of them:

What must match	Where it goes wrong
Shipper or exporter legal name	BL shows a trading name; IEC shows the registered name
8-digit HS code	Invoice at 8 digits, shipping bill at 6
Product description wording	Invoice says 'cotton T-shirt', packing list says 'garment'
Quantity and unit of measure	Pieces on the invoice, dozens on the packing list
Net and gross weight	Weight list updated after the invoice was issued
Invoice number and date	Retyped by the CHA with a different format
Value and currency	Invoice value stated excluding freight on a CIF quote

Discrepancies, not gaps

Customs systems cross-verify your invoice, packing list, shipping bill and GST return automatically. A mismatch flags instantly and holds the Let Export Order. A missing document is a delay; a mismatch is an investigation. Build one data sheet and fill every document from it, rather than retyping each form.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Incoterms and pricing your first quote

Who pays what, where risk passes, and a costing sheet that stops you from quoting a price that loses money on the freight.

The five terms a first-timer will meet

Term	You pay for	Risk passes to buyer	Use it when
EXW — Ex Works	Nothing beyond making the goods available at your premises	At your door	The buyer has their own agent in India. Simplest for you, weakest for the buyer
FOB — Free On Board	Inland transport to the port, export clearance, loading on the vessel	When goods are on board	**The default for a first export.** You know your costs, the buyer controls freight
CFR / CIF	FOB costs plus ocean freight (CIF adds insurance)	When goods are on board, even though you paid the freight	The buyer asks for a delivered-to-port price. You are now buying freight and carrying risk you do not control
DAP — Delivered At Place	Everything to the buyer's named place, excluding import duty	At the destination	Rarely for a first shipment. You are liable for destination charges you cannot see
DDP — Delivered Duty Paid	Everything, including the buyer's import duty	At the buyer's door	Only if you have a destination agent and a duty estimate in writing

Quote FOB on your first order

FOB makes your price comparable with every other Indian supplier, keeps the freight quote in the buyer's hands where they can audit it, and removes the risk of a destination charge wiping out your margin. Move to CIF only when a buyer insists and you have a forwarder quote in writing.

The costing sheet

Fill this in before you quote anything. Every rupee you forget here comes straight out of your margin, because a fixed FOB price does not move once the buyer accepts it.

1. Ex-works cost of goods (per unit × quantity)	
2. Export packing, cartons, marks, pallets	
3. Inland freight to port or airport	
4. Customs broker fee	
5. Documentation, courier, certificate of origin	
6. Terminal handling, port charges, CHA disbursements	
7. Testing or certification, amortised over the order	
8. Bank charges and remittance fees	
9. Contingency (5–8% is normal, not pessimistic)	
A. Total FOB cost	
10. Your margin (percentage or fixed)	
B. FOB price = A + margin	
11. Per-unit price in foreign currency at today's RBI reference rate	

A worked example

Five hundred cotton T-shirts, ex-works ₹280 each, so ₹1,40,000 in goods. Packing ₹4,000. Inland freight to Mumbai ₹6,000. Customs broker ₹4,000. Documents and courier ₹1,500. Terminal handling ₹5,000. That gives a total FOB cost of **₹1,60,500**, or ₹321 per piece.

Add a 25% margin and your FOB price is **₹2,00,625** — about ₹401 per piece. At an assumed RBI reference rate of ₹90 to the dollar, that is a quote of **US$4.46 per piece FOB Nhava Sheva**. Substitute today's actual rate when you send the quote; the rate on the invoice date is the one that has to appear on the invoice.

Now the same order with a 12% margin instead: ₹3,59,760, or US$4.00 per piece. That is the entire negotiating room, and it is why the costing sheet matters more than the sales pitch.

What the schemes do to that number

- **RoDTEP** pays a percentage of FOB value as a transferable scrip. At an assumed 1% rate on a ₹2,00,625 FOB, that is about ₹2,000 — small on one order, meaningful over a year. The actual rate for your line is in Appendix 4R. The scheme's notified end date is 31 December 2026.
- **Duty drawback** pays the All Industry Rate for your code, declared at the shipping bill.
- You can claim RoDTEP and drawback on the same shipment — they remit different duties. What you cannot do is claim a refund of input tax credit and simultaneously claim the central-tax element of drawback.

Treat both as a margin recovery, never as the reason a deal works. A scheme with a sunset date cannot underwrite a three-year contract.

CHAPTER NINE

Getting paid, and the 15-month clock

The single biggest risk in a first export is not customs. It is a buyer who takes the goods and pays late, or not at all — and the clock that decides when that becomes your problem with RBI.

Payment terms, ranked for a first order

Term	What it means	Your risk	Ask for it when
100% advance	Buyer pays before you ship	Almost none	First order, small value, new buyer. Always your opening ask
30% advance, 70% before dispatch	Deposit, balance against documents or before loading	Low	The realistic compromise for a first order with a buyer you have verified
30% advance, 70% against shipping documents	Balance released when you present the document set	Moderate	Repeat orders after one clean transaction
Letter of credit at sight	Bank guarantees payment against compliant documents	Low, if the documents are perfect	Larger orders. A single typo in the LC documents voids the protection
Documents against payment (DP)	Buyer's bank releases documents only on payment	Moderate	Established relationships. The buyer can simply refuse the documents
Open account / 60–90 days	Goods ship, payment later on invoice	High	Never on a first order, whatever the buyer promises

The line that protects you

On a first order with a new buyer, the advance is not a negotiating position — it is the test. A buyer who refuses any advance on a first transaction is telling you something about how the payment will go. A buyer who agrees to 30% has committed real money to the relationship.

The 15-month realisation rule

Under FEMA, you must realise and repatriate the full value of the export within the prescribed period. Since the Foreign Exchange Management (Export of Goods and Services) (Second Amendment) Regulations, 2025 — FEMA 23(R)/(7)/2025-RB, dated 13 November 2025 — that period is **fifteen months from the date of export**, up from nine months. It applies uniformly to goods, software and services, and to SEZ units, EOUs and status holders alike.

The same amendment extended the window for shipping goods against an advance payment received from overseas from one year to **three years**. Both changes came into force on publication in the gazette on 14 November 2025.

- The clock starts on the **date of export** — the shipping bill date — not the invoice date and not the date the buyer promised to pay.

- Fifteen months is a deadline, not a relaxation of the duty to realise. Missing it without RBI permission is a contravention under Section 8 of FEMA, with a penalty of up to three times the amount involved or ₹2 lakh, whichever is higher.
- If a payment genuinely will not arrive in time, the extension has to be applied for **before** the deadline, through your AD bank. Not after.

The paperwork that proves you were paid

When money arrives, your bank issues a **FIRC** (Foreign Inward Remittance Certificate) for services and an **e-BRC** (electronic Bank Realisation Certificate) for goods, which is now pushed to the DGFT system and matched against your shipping bills. That match is what closes the transaction in EDPMS, the Export Data Processing and Monitoring System.

- **Reconcile monthly, not annually.** Compare each shipping bill against its e-BRC value while the difference is still a phone call to your bank. Six months later it is a claim that has already narrowed.
- Small-value shipping bills up to **₹10 lakh** can now be closed by your AD bank on quarterly declarations from you, rather than a document-by-document reconciliation. Use it — it removes a monthly chore for small consignments.
- A value mismatch between the shipping bill and the e-BRC is the standard reason a RoDTEP or drawback claim gets stuck. It is almost always a freight or insurance line that was included on one document and not the other.

When the buyer does not pay

1. Escalate inside the fifteen months, not after. Your AD bank can approve write-off within its delegated limits; the RBI route exists but is slower and needs a genuine attempt at recovery on record.
2. Keep the evidence: the contract or PO, every email, the shipping documents, the reminders, the courier proofs. A write-off application is decided on the paper trail.
3. Do not ship a second consignment to a buyer with an overdue first one. This is the single most common way a small exporter's receivables double.

CHAPTER TEN

GST on exports without losing money

Two legal routes, two different refund mechanisms, one two-year deadline. Most first-timers file correctly and still wait months, because of a mismatch in a single field.

Route A — Export under LUT (Rule 89)

You charge no IGST. Your input credit accumulates, and you recover it by filing **Form GST RFD-01** on the GST portal. The refund is calculated on a formula:

Refund = (Turnover of zero-rated supply ÷ Adjusted total turnover) × Net ITC

- You can file for multiple tax periods in one application, including across two financial years.
- The application can be saved as a draft for 15 days; after that the draft is purged and you start again.
- A provisional refund of up to 90% of the amount claimed is available for zero-rated supplies, and has to be released quickly once the acknowledgement is issued.
- Only ITC on inputs and input services counts. ITC on capital goods is not refundable under this route — if that is where your credit sits, exporting on payment of IGST is the better route.

Route B — Export on payment of IGST (Rule 96)

You charge IGST on the export invoice, pay it in GSTR-3B, and the **shipping bill itself is treated as the refund application**. No separate form. The GST portal transmits the invoice data to ICEGATE, customs validates it against the shipping bill and the export manifest, and the refund is credited.

It is the faster route, and it fails for boring reasons. These are the validations the GST system runs before it will transmit your data at all:

- GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B for the period are both filed.
- Export invoices are reported in **Table 6A of GSTR-1**, with the correct shipping bill number, shipping bill date and the six-character port code.
- The invoice number in Table 6A is identical to the one on the shipping bill.
- The WPAY / WOPAY flag (with or without payment of tax) is correct for each invoice.
- IGST is reported in **Table 3.1(b)** of GSTR-3B — not 3.1(a), not 3.1(c) — and is equal to or greater than the IGST shown in Table 6A.

One digit is enough to break it

A GSTIN, invoice number, invoice date or taxable value that differs by a single character between GSTR-1 and the shipping bill stops the automatic refund. Check those four fields against the shipping bill before you file the return, not after the refund fails.

Which route for your first shipment

Your situation	Route	Why
You buy raw material or packaging with GST and want that credit back	LUT, then RFD-01	The credit accumulates and you recover it under Rule 89. Exporting on payment of IGST would mean funding the tax first
You are a trader with little input credit, shipping once or twice a year	IGST paid, Rule 96	The shipping bill is the refund application. No RFD-01, no statement of invoices, no officer queue
You have significant ITC on capital goods	IGST paid, Rule 96	Capital goods credit is not refundable under the LUT route, so the money stays locked
You are not sure yet	LUT	You can switch to the IGST route later. Switching the other way means an ITC balance you cannot easily recover

The deadline nobody puts on the invoice

A refund claim has to be filed within **two years of the relevant date** under Section 54 of the CGST Act. For export of goods, the relevant date is the date of the shipping bill. For export of services, it is the date the foreign exchange was received. Unclaimed refunds from FY 2023-24 are reaching the end of that window now.

Practical notes that save a month

- Prepare the refund statement using the GST portal's Excel-based offline utility. The older PDF route for refund statements is closed.
- Sanction is required within 60 days of a complete application, and interest applies if it is not. 'Complete' is the operative word — a deficiency memo restarts the clock.
- Before filing, reconcile four ways: GSTR-1 against GSTR-3B, shipping bill against invoice, ICEGATE against the GST portal, and books against returns. The refund officer checks the same four.
- E-invoicing applies where your turnover crosses the notified threshold. If you cross it mid-year, your export invoices change format — check before the first invoice of the new period.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

RoDTEP and drawback, before the clock runs out

Two schemes remit two different sets of taxes. Both are claimed at the shipping bill. One of them has a hard end date of 31 December 2026.

RoDTEP — what it is

The Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products scheme refunds embedded central, state and local duties and taxes that are not otherwise rebated — things like VAT and central excise on the transport of inputs, electricity duty, stamp duty on export documents, and embedded GST paid to unregistered suppliers. It is paid as a **transferable scrip** at a percentage of FOB value, set per product line in Appendix 4R.

The 2026 timeline, exactly

Effective from	Notification	What happened
23 Feb 2026	DGFT 60/2025-26 (with corrigendum of 24 Feb)	Rates and caps halved, except for Chapters 01 to 24
23 Mar 2026	DGFT 66/2025-26	Full rates restored for the 23 Feb to 31 Mar 2026 window, cancelling the cut retrospectively
1 Apr 2026	DGFT 74/2025-26 (31 Mar 2026)	Scheme extended six months to 30 September 2026; rates and caps unchanged
1 May 2026	DGFT 15/2026-27 (30 Apr 2026)	Appendix 4R and 4RE realigned to the amended Customs Tariff
1 Oct 2026	DGFT 41/2026-27 (30 Sep 2026)	Extended to **31 December 2026**; rates and caps as on 30 September 2026 continue unchanged

What the 31 December 2026 date means for you

The scheme is notified up to that date, for DTA units, Advance Authorisation holders, SEZ units and EOUs. Exports inside the window earn the benefit at the notified rates. If your shipment is going to be close to the boundary, the date that matters is the Let Export Order, not when you file the claim. Beyond 31 December 2026, treat RoDTEP as absent from your pricing until a further notification appears.

How the claim actually works

1. The RoDTEP flag is ticked on the **shipping bill at the time of filing**. A blank flag is not repaired by anything you do later.
2. Eligibility and rate come from the 8-digit code on that shipping bill. Wrong code, wrong rate — and after the Let Export Order, that shipping bill is fixed.
3. The scrip is issued electronically, is transferable, and can be used to pay Basic Customs Duty on imports or sold to another importer.
4. RoDTEP is also available on courier-mode exports, along with duty drawback, since CBIC Notification 60/2024-Customs (N.T.) and Circular 15/2024-Customs, both dated 12 September 2024. A small courier

consignment is not excluded from the scheme.

Duty drawback — what it is

Drawback refunds customs duty paid on imported inputs that go into an export product. It is claimed at the All Industry Rate published for your code, also declared on the shipping bill. Where no All Industry Rate exists, a brand-rate or fixed-rate claim is possible but needs a cost working.

- Drawback and RoDTEP can be claimed on the same shipping bill — they remit different duties.
- What you cannot do is claim a refund of input tax credit and simultaneously claim the central-tax element of drawback on the same goods.
- Drawback is not available where the export product is subject to export duty, or where the input was already duty-free.
- Reconcile the drawback credit against the e-BRC value of that shipping bill, the same way you would for RoDTEP.

The three schemes you should not chase

Advance Authorisation and EPCG are duty-exemption schemes for importers who need inputs or capital goods without paying duty upfront. They are genuinely valuable — and completely wrong for a first shipment, because they require an RCMC, an application, a bond or bank guarantee, and an export obligation you have to track for years. Interest equalisation and the older SEIS-type incentives are either closed or subject to change; check the Department of Commerce position before you build any of them into a quote.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Finding your first ten buyers

Six channels that actually produce enquiries for an Indian exporter with no track record, and the exact words to send when someone replies.

Channel 1 — Your Export Promotion Council

This is the most underused channel in India and the only one where the buyers are pre-qualified by product category. Councils run buyer-seller meets, inbound delegations, and subsidised participation in international fairs under the Export Promotion Mission's market access component. Membership is not needed for a shipment under ₹3 lakh FOB, but it is the price of entry to the buyer lists.

The practical action: find your council in the table in Chapter 3, call the regional office, and ask two specific questions — which buyer-seller meets are scheduled in the next two quarters for my product line, and what is the subsidy available to a first-time participant. Vague emails get no reply; those two questions get a calendar.

Channel 2 — Trade Connect and the Indian Missions

The Trade Connect ePlatform at trade.gov.in consolidates market information from Indian Missions, councils and commodity boards. More usefully, every Indian embassy has a commercial wing whose job includes matching local buyers with Indian suppliers. A short, specific email with your product list, capacity, price band and certifications to the commercial counsellor in your target market is read more often than you would expect.

Channel 3 — Importers in your destination, found properly

Do not search for 'buyers of T-shirts'. Search for the distributors and retailers who already sell your category, and approach them as a supplier who has done homework. The difference in reply rate between a mass email and one that references a specific product on the buyer's own website is enormous.

Channel 4 — Marketplaces, used honestly

Amazon Global Selling and similar programmes are a real route for consumer products, and they come with fulfilment and duty-collection infrastructure that removes most of the operational risk. What they do not remove is the need for your own IEC and GST, or the fact that your margin after platform fees, fulfilment and returns is much thinner than the sticker price suggests. Model it before you list.

Channel 5 — The Exporter-on-Record route

Under the framework operationalised in August 2026, a registered Exporter-on-Record buys from Indian sellers and handles export compliance. If you are a manufacturer or artisan who wants the order without the paperwork, this is the route designed for you — with the 7-day payment rule and the 10% cap on the administrative charge written into the framework. Read the agreement for those two numbers specifically.

Channel 6 — Trade fairs, in person

Physical fairs still convert better than any email for first-time exporters, because a buyer can see and touch the product and judge whether you are real. Choose one fair in one market rather than three in none, and go with a printed catalogue, samples, a price list in the buyer's currency on FOB terms, and a one-page company profile

with your IEC and certifications.

The first email — what to send

Four sentences, no brochure attachment on the first contact, and a specific ask. This is the structure that works:

> **Subject: Cotton knitwear supplier, Tiruppur — samples for [Buyer company]**
>
> Dear [Name],
>
> I supply [specific product] from [city], India, and I saw that [Buyer company] carries [specific product line] in [market]. We make [capacity] pieces a month at [price band] FOB [port], with [certification].
>
> I can courier two samples to your office this week at my cost, and I can hold a first-order price for 30 days. Would a 20-minute call next week be useful?
>
> [Name], [Company], IEC [number], [phone], [website]

What to do with a reply

- **Answer price with a structure, not a number.** State the unit price, the Incoterm, the port, the MOQ, the lead time and the validity period in one line. A bare number invites a counter-offer with no basis.
- **Send the sample only after you have their full company details.** Free samples to unverified addresses is the most common small loss in export.
- **Ask for their registration number or a trade reference** in the second email. A genuine buyer supplies it without drama.
- **Quote in the buyer's currency, but record the INR value at the RBI reference rate on the quote date**, so a currency move does not silently eat your margin.

> **Six copy-paste messages you will need**
>
> 1. First contact (above). 2. Price quote with Incoterm, MOQ and validity. 3. Sample dispatch note with the courier tracking number. 4. Payment terms proposal with the advance percentage. 5. Follow-up after no reply, sent on day 5 and day 12, referencing one new piece of information. 6. Order confirmation that restates the product, quantity, price, Incoterm, port, payment terms, lead time and inspection terms — because the dispute you will have in month three is about which of those six was agreed.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Buyer verification and the scams

Export fraud is not exotic. It is mostly three patterns, and all three are visible before you ship if you spend twenty minutes checking.

Twenty minutes of verification

1. Search the company name plus the word 'scam', 'complaint' and 'fraud'. Read the second page of results, not the first.
2. Ask for the company's registration number in its own country and check it on that country's registry. Most have a free public search.
3. Ask for two trade references — other suppliers, ideally in Asia — and actually email them. A buyer who will not give references has a reason.
4. Check that the email domain matches the website, and that the website has existed for more than a few months. A Gmail address for a company claiming to import containers is a signal.
5. Look at the shipping address on the PO against the registered address. Different countries, or a residential address for a bulk order, is a signal.
6. Never accept a change of bank details by email without a phone call to a number you already had. This is the single most expensive fraud in export.

Pattern 1 — The fake order that needs your money first

A large order arrives unsolicited, with generous terms, and then a request: pay the 'registration fee', the 'inspection agent', the 'customs clearance deposit', or use their nominated freight forwarder who demands an advance. The order is the bait; the fee is the business. Any buyer who asks you to pay a third party before they have paid you anything is not a buyer.

Pattern 2 — The letter of credit that cannot be complied with

An LC looks like safety and is only safety if you can produce every document it lists, exactly as listed, inside the stated periods. Fraudulent or simply careless LCs specify documents you cannot obtain, a shipment date already passed, or a discrepancy trap that lets the issuing bank refuse. Before accepting an LC, read the document list line by line and confirm with your bank that each one is obtainable. If the LC comes from a small bank in a jurisdiction you cannot check, treat it as an open account with extra steps.

Pattern 3 — The chargeback after delivery

Card payments and some platform payments can be reversed after the goods have shipped. For orders of any size, insist on bank transfer into your account. If a buyer insists on a card or a consumer payment app for a commercial order, that is the risk being transferred to you.

> **The one rule**
> No shipment without either the money or an instrument you can verify independently. Everything else — the flattery, the volume, the promise of a repeat order — costs you nothing to hear and a container to believe.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The 30-day launch plan

Thirty days, in the order the dependencies actually fall. Each block is a day's work, not a week's.

Days	What you finish	Done looks like
1 – 2	Product and market check	8-digit code, export policy read, SCOMET checked, destination requirement identified
3 – 4	Entity and bank	Current account in the firm's name, name spelled identically everywhere
5 – 6	IEC application	₹500 paid, IEC issued, PDF saved with the date you will update it next April
7 – 9	GST registration	GSTIN issued and the certificate downloaded
10	LUT for the financial year	Form GST RFD-11 filed, ARN saved, declaration wording added to your invoice template
11 – 12	ICEGATE and AD Code	AD Code registered at the port you will use, PFMS validation passed
13	Invoice and packing list templates	Every field from Chapter 7 present in a single spreadsheet that feeds both documents
14	Classification note	One dated page with the 8-digit code and the reasoning
15 – 16	Costing sheet	Chapter 8 sheet filled with real quotes from two forwarders and one CHA
17 – 20	Buyer outreach	Council contacted, 30 target buyers listed, first-contact emails sent to 20
21 – 24	Samples and quotes	Two samples dispatched with tracking, three quotes issued on FOB terms
25 – 27	First order confirmation	PO with product, quantity, price, Incoterm, port, payment terms, lead time, inspection terms
28 – 30	Shipment preparation	Six-document set drafted, six-way match run, RoDTEP and drawback flags confirmed with the CHA

If you only have one week

Do days 1 to 6 and day 15. Product legality, an IEC and a real costing sheet are the three things that stop you from losing money. Everything else can be learned on a live shipment with a small order, and a small order is a better teacher than a perfect plan.

The first shipment should be small on purpose

Your objective on shipment one is not profit. It is a complete, clean cycle: a real buyer, a real shipping bill, a real Let Export Order, a real payment into your bank, and an e-BRC that matches. That cycle teaches you more than a year of reading, and it produces the track record that makes shipment two easier — with your bank, with your council, and with the next buyer.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The twelve most expensive mistakes

Every one of these is common, every one is avoidable, and most of them cost more than the entire setup budget.

Mistake	What it costs	The fix
Wrong HS code on the shipping bill	Wrong RoDTEP and drawback rate, wrong destination duty, seizure risk on a restricted item, and it cannot be repaired after the Let Export Order	Written classification note before the first invoice
No AD Code at the actual port	The shipping bill cannot be filed at all	Register at the loading port, not the nearest one
LUT not filed for the year	IGST has to be paid and recovered, blocking working capital for weeks	File RFD-11 in April, before the first export invoice
Invoice and packing list descriptions differ	Let Export Order held, shipment misses the vessel, buyer is angry	One data sheet, every document generated from it
BL shipper name differs from the IEC	Customs query, telex release delay, buyer refuses documents	Give the forwarder your exact IEC name in writing
RoDTEP flag left blank	1–3% of FOB lost permanently on a large shipment	Confirm the flags with the CHA before submission
Shipping bill and e-BRC values do not match	Claim stuck for months, then often abandoned	Reconcile monthly, not at claim time
GSTR-1 Table 6A details do not match the shipping bill	Automatic IGST refund fails	Check the four fields before filing the return
No advance from a new buyer	The entire consignment becomes a bad debt	30% minimum on a first order
Paying a 'registration' or 'inspection' fee to a buyer's nominated party	The fee, and the order was never real	No payment to any third party before the buyer pays you
Missing the 30 June IEC update	IEC deactivates, shipments stop, reactivation costs a week	Calendar it on 1 April every year
Quoting CIF or DDP on a first order	Freight and destination charges you did not price	Quote FOB until you have a forwarder quote in writing

The pattern behind all twelve

Eleven of the twelve are sequence errors, not knowledge errors. People know what an IEC is; they apply for it after they have a buyer. They know a shipping bill needs a code; they pick the code after the invoice is issued. Move the decisions earlier than the paperwork and almost all of this disappears.

APPENDIX A

The 2026-27 compliance calendar

Print this. It is the whole of your recurring export compliance in one table.

When	What	Consequence of missing it
1 April	File the LUT in Form GST RFD-11 for the new financial year	IGST becomes payable on exports until it is filed
1 April – 30 June	IEC annual update on dgft.gov.in (free)	IEC deactivates automatically from 1 July
Every month	GSTR-1 with export invoices in Table 6A, including shipping bill number, date and port code	IGST refund blocked; ITC refund deficiency
Every month	GSTR-3B, with IGST in Table 3.1(b) where you exported on payment of tax	Refund data not transmitted to ICEGATE
Every month	Match each shipping bill against its e-BRC	RoDTEP and drawback claims stuck; EDPMS stays open
Every quarter	Small-value declaration to your AD bank for shipping bills up to ₹10 lakh	Open entries accumulate in EDPMS
Within 15 months of each export	Realise and repatriate the full export value	FEMA contravention under Section 8, penalty up to three times the amount
Within 2 years of the shipping bill date	File the ITC refund in Form GST RFD-01	Refund lapses
31 December 2026	RoDTEP notified end date	Shipments after this date earn no RoDTEP until further notice
Annually	Reconcile the drawback and RoDTEP credits received against the shipping bills claimed	Unclaimed scrips and mismatched drawback

APPENDIX B

Pre-shipment checklist

Work down this list once per consignment. It takes fifteen minutes and it catches almost everything.

Before the order is confirmed

- ☐ 8-digit ITC(HS) code fixed on a written classification note
- ☐ Export policy for that code read in Schedule 2 of ITC(HS) — Free, Restricted or Prohibited
- ☐ SCOMET position checked if the product is chemicals, electronics, drones or machine tools
- ☐ Destination market's mandatory certification identified, with the lead time for obtaining it
- ☐ Buyer verified: registration number, two trade references, email domain, address
- ☐ Payment terms agreed in writing, with the advance percentage stated
- ☐ Incoterm and named port written into the PO, not left to the invoice

Before the invoice is issued

- ☐ LUT for the current financial year on file, ARN to hand
- ☐ Invoice number series is consistent and has not been reused
- ☐ 8-digit HS code on every line
- ☐ Invoice value in foreign currency and INR, with the RBI reference rate used
- ☐ Declaration wording present: supply meant for export without payment of IGST under LUT, with the ARN
- ☐ Bank details and AD Code on the invoice
- ☐ Product description written exactly as it will appear on the packing list and shipping bill

Before the shipping bill is filed

- ☐ AD Code live on ICEGATE at the actual loading port
- ☐ PFMS bank validation passed
- ☐ RoDTEP claim flag and drawback flag confirmed with the CHA
- ☐ Shipping bill draft checked line by line against the invoice
- ☐ Shipper name on the draft BL identical to the IEC legal name
- ☐ Documents uploaded to eSanchit and the IRNs quoted correctly
- ☐ Certificate of Origin applied for, if the buyer or the trade agreement needs one

After the Let Export Order

- ☐ Let Export Order copy saved with the shipping bill
- ☐ BL or AWB checked against the shipping bill before release
- ☐ Export invoice reported in GSTR-1 Table 6A with the correct shipping bill details
- ☐ Payment due date diarised, counting fifteen months from the shipping bill date
- ☐ Reminder set to reconcile the e-BRC against the shipping bill value on receipt

APPENDIX C

Costing worksheet

One page, filled in before every quote. Photocopy it or rebuild it as a spreadsheet — the discipline matters more than the format.

Order reference and buyer	
Product, 8-digit code, quantity	
Ex-works cost per unit × quantity	
Export packing, cartons, pallets, marks	
Inland freight to port or airport	
Customs broker fee	
Documentation, courier, certificate of origin	
Terminal handling and port charges	
Testing and certification, amortised	
Bank charges and remittance fees	
Contingency at 5–8%	
Total FOB cost	
Margin, as a percentage of FOB cost	
FOB price	
FOB price per unit in INR	
RBI reference rate on quote date	
FOB price per unit in foreign currency	
RoDTEP expected at the Appendix 4R rate for this code	
Drawback expected at the All Industry Rate for this code	
Net realisation after schemes	
Quote validity date	

Two habits

Recalculate the foreign-currency price on the day you send the quote, not the day you made the sheet. And write the validity period on the quote — 15 or 30 days — so a currency move or a freight change is a new quote, not an argument.

APPENDIX D

Portals, sources and what to verify where

Every authority named in this kit, with the one thing you go there for.

Authority	Portal	What you go there for
DGFT	dgft.gov.in	IEC application and annual update, ITC(HS) Schedule 2 export policy, SCOMET list, RoDTEP Appendix 4R and 4RE, all notifications, e-RCMC, Certificate of Origin
DGFT	coo.dgft.gov.in	Electronic Certificate of Origin
CBIC / Indian Customs	icegate.gov.in	AD Code registration, shipping bill tracking, eSanchit document upload, IGST refund status
GSTN	gst.gov.in	GST registration, LUT in Form GST RFD-11, GSTR-1 Table 6A, GSTR-3B, refund in Form GST RFD-01
RBI	rbi.org.in	FEMA notifications, the 15-month realisation rule, reference exchange rates
Department of Commerce	trade.gov.in	Trade Connect ePlatform, market information from Indian Missions
MSME Ministry	udyamregistration.gov.in	Udyam registration
India Post	indiapost.gov.in	Dak Ghar Niryat Kendra locations and the International Tracked Packet Service

The specific instruments cited in this kit

- FEMA 23(R)/(7)/2025-RB, 13 November 2025 (gazetted 14 November 2025): realisation period to fifteen months, advance-shipment window to three years.
- DGFT Notification 27/2026-27 and Public Notice 25/2026-27, 5 August 2026: inventory-based cross-border e-commerce framework, Form ANF-9A.
- DGFT Notification 36/2026-27, 15 September 2026: RCMC not required for consignments up to ₹3 lakh FOB.
- DGFT Notification 41/2026-27, 30 September 2026: RoDTEP continued to 31 December 2026.
- DGFT Notification 15/2026-27, 30 April 2026: RoDTEP schedule realigned to the amended Customs Tariff from 1 May 2026.
- DGFT Notification 67/2025-26, 27 March 2026, with CBIC Notifications 33/2026-Cus (N.T.) and 34/2026-Cus (N.T.) and Circular 17/2026-Customs: courier export value cap removed from 1 April 2026, return-to-origin facility, simplified re-import of rejects.
- CBIC Notification 60/2024-Customs (N.T.) and Circular 15/2024-Customs, both 12 September 2024: RoDTEP and drawback extended to courier-mode exports.
- CBIC Circular 24/2025-Customs, 7 October 2025: auto-approval of the same account and IFSC for AD Codes at further ports.
- DGFT Notification 58/2015-20, 12 February 2021: the annual IEC update. Form GST RFD-11 under Rule 96A of the CGST Rules for the LUT; Rules 89 and 96 for the two refund routes; Section 54 of the CGST Act for the two-year limit.

All positions here were checked on 3 November 2026. Notifications change often — verify on the issuing authority's portal before a live shipment.

APPENDIX E

Glossary

The sixteen terms that appear in every conversation about a first export.

AD Code	A 14-digit identifier issued by your bank that maps one branch account to one customs location on ICEGATE
All Industry Rate	The published duty drawback rate for a product code
BL / AWB	Bill of lading (sea) or air waybill (air): the carrier's document evidencing the contract of carriage
CHA	Customs house agent, or customs broker — files the shipping bill on your behalf
CoO	Certificate of Origin: proves where the goods were made, and unlocks preferential duty under a trade agreement
e-BRC	Electronic Bank Realisation Certificate: your bank's confirmation that export proceeds were received
ECEH	E-Commerce Export Hub: a notified facility bundling customs clearance, warehousing and packaging for e-commerce consignments
EDPMS	Export Data Processing and Monitoring System: RBI's system for tracking whether export proceeds came in
EOR / SOR	Exporter-on-Record and Seller-on-Record under the inventory-based cross-border e-commerce framework
FIRC	Foreign Inward Remittance Certificate, the services equivalent of an e-BRC
FOB	Free On Board: your price includes delivery to and loading on the vessel at the named port
HS / ITC(HS)	The product classification code. Eight digits in India; the first six are international
IEC	Importer Exporter Code, issued by DGFT, mandatory for commercial export
LEO	Let Export Order: customs' permission for the goods to leave. The point after which the shipping bill is effectively fixed
LUT	Letter of Undertaking in Form GST RFD-11: lets you export without paying IGST upfront
RCMC	Registration-cum-Membership Certificate from an Export Promotion Council. Not required up to ₹3 lakh FOB
RoDTEP	Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products: a transferable scrip paid as a percentage of FOB value
Shipping bill	The customs export declaration filed on ICEGATE, and the basis of your RoDTEP, drawback and GST refund claims

One last thing

The exporters who succeed on their first attempt are rarely the ones who understood the most before starting. They are the ones who did the boring sequence in the right order, shipped something small, and read their own documents before customs did.